The Ballast and the Open Days

For the learner who joins a season later - guide-facing · spiral edition

Printed 2026-10-21

The Ballast and the Open Days - for the learner who joins a season later

Status: v0.1 working draft, authored 2026-09-25 from the 8-voice fleet meeting (third sitting: Jake Sisko, Naomi Wildman, Pavel Chekov, Kira Nerys, Ibn Khaldun, Comes, Accord, Cura). **Companions:** `2028-2029-launch-pad-studio-year-plan-forge-v0.1.md` (the joiner scaffold, already specified), `2026-06-24-launch-pad-three-year-story-cycle-v0.1.md` (the cycle, the portable foundation), `2027-2028-launch-pad-first-cohort-conversation-v0.1.md` (the door), `launch-pad-promotion-and-the-not-shown-wall-v0.1.md` (what may be shown). **Minutes:** `evoke-agents-backup/agents/meetings/2026/09/2026-09-25-launch-pad-the-waiting-learner.md`

---

0. The first thing to say to the family

There is no Year One to miss.

The Launch Pad is a cycle, not a ladder. The seasons are Origin, The Forge, and The Helm, and they turn. A learner who starts at The Forge in August 2028 walks The Forge, then The Helm, then Origin, and launches having walked all three. The design refuses the words "Year 1 / Year 2 / Year 3" precisely because they rank a learner who enters mid-cycle as behind, and that learner is not behind.

More than that: **The Forge is the kindest season to enter cold.** The year plan says so in its own words. It is outward at a shared problem rather than baring an interior, and mixed tenure is a resource there, not a gap. A learner who cannot be in the room this year and can be next year is not settling for a worse door. In some ways they are getting the better one.

So the honest answer to "can we give them packets?" is: **yes, a small one, and it is not a year of Origin at a distance.** The room is always better than the packet, and the design has already built everything they need for the day they arrive.

---

1. What already exists (so we do not build it twice)

The Forge year plan specifies a **joiner scaffold** that must be built before any mid-cycle joiner arrives. Four parts:

1. **The Fast-Origin seed** - about two to three weeks, embedded in the joiner's own self-guided blocks in weeks 1 to 3, explicitly *not* a parallel Origin: a rapid 100 Dreams, an agency inventory, and a routine that holds. The three Origin functions The Forge silently stands on. Re-enterable, never a gate.
2. **The Captain's Log from day one** - "every Log starts empty; yours starts now, same first page." By lens, never by page count.
3. **A returner peer-witness pairing** - reciprocal, not tutoring. The joiner witnesses a returner's carried-forward dream; the returner witnesses the joiner naming theirs.
4. **A shared threshold season-opener** the whole room crosses together, and **no visible catch-up** - the seed lives in the joiner's own blocks, and in the shared deep hour they are a full Forge learner from the first morning.

Read that carefully: the joiner needs nothing before they arrive. The readiness is built in the room, by design, in their first three weeks. Nothing in The Ballast is a prerequisite, and nothing in it is remedial.

---

2. What The Ballast is

Ballast is what a ship carries low in the hull to stay steady in open water. It is not cargo, and it is not homework.

A small paper packet, given once, to a named learner who has said yes and is waiting a season. Four things, and no more.

What	Why it travels safely	Notes
A Captain's Log	It is theirs, carried all three years anyway. Starting it during the wait is pure gain and carries no interior risk the design has not already accepted	The real notebook, named by them. Captured however they hold it: written, spoken, drawn, dictated, or told to someone beside them. No form is the lesser Log
The 100 Dreams card	Already designed as a Day-1 take-home. It is expansive, not excavating: it asks what you want, never what happened to you	The rule, the wall at forty, the warm spark bank. Bring the list when you come. **The dream session happens in the room**

What	Why it travels safely	Notes
The Vineyard card	Un-harvested joy. Nothing is reported, so nothing can go wrong	“There is a part of each week that is just yours to love. Nobody will ever ask what it was for.” Named now, tended for as long as they like
A Weekly Plan pad	A routine that holds is the most transferable of Origin’s three functions, and the least interior	The accessible version with starter banks, not blank lines

That is the whole packet. It maps onto the Fast-Origin seed’s own three functions plus the two carried objects, and it does not duplicate the agency inventory, which is better done in the room in week two.

---

3. What is deliberately NOT in it

This half matters more than the first half.

- **The Lineage (Origin Session 2)** and the mortality listening. It needs the preview, the real exit, the room, and the potluck.
- **The Full Draft (Origin Session 5).** The worst day, the loss, the whole life written out. This is the heaviest interior surface in the program. Alone, unheld, with no somatic floor, no guide watching the room, and no referral pathway in reach, it is precisely what the safety architecture forbids. **This one is not a preference. It is the floor.**
- **Chapter One (Origin Session 6).** The shrink mechanic needs a guide holding it, or “cut to focus, never to hide” collapses into cutting to hide.
- **The Unveiling (Origin Session 7).** It needs an audience and a feast.
- **The dream session.** You can write a hundred dreams alone. You cannot have the dream session alone, because the whole mechanism is that dreams are contagious in a room.
- **Any Socratic work.** That is a conversation, not a worksheet.
- **Anything to submit, complete, review, or be graded on.** There is no such thing anywhere in this program, and a packet is exactly where it would sneak back in.

---

4. The five rules that keep it from becoming something else

1. **No guide obligation.** No check-ins, no submissions, no feedback, no deadline, no reply owed. If the guide must hold the waiting learner, a second cohort has been created without anyone deciding to create one, and the capacity ceiling that keeps this program honest has been breached quietly.
2. **Nothing comes back.** Nothing in The Ballast is read by anyone, ever. Not the guide, not a parent. Same rule as the Log, for the same reason.
3. **Arriving empty is arriving fine.** A learner who opens none of it and walks in next August is not behind, is never treated as behind, and hears that said out loud on their first day. The empty basket is a true harvest here too. If The Ballast ever produces a two-tier room, the ones who did it and the ones who did not, it has harmed the thing it was meant to serve.
4. **Never sold, never scaled.** The Ballast goes to named learners on the waitlist who have said yes. It is not a product, not a sample, not a lead magnet, and not a warm thing we send so a family does not go elsewhere. That last one is a re-engagement hook, and re-engagement hooks are on the "deliberately NOT built" wall.
5. **Cheap, portable, and printer-free.** A notebook, three cards, a pad. No supplies to buy, no quiet desk assumed, no parent required to help. The learner who cannot be in the room this year often cannot be there because of a job, a sibling to care for, a distance, or money. A packet that needs a study and a helpful adult is a packet for a different family.

Plus Chekov's floor, which is not optional: large print by default, left-aligned sans serif, high contrast, and every prompt answerable by voice or drawing.

---

5. The Open Days - better than the packet

The waiting learner is not a correspondence student. They are a person the room already said yes to, who is not in it yet. Cohesion is built by walking somewhere together, never by mail.

So the guide invites them to the parts of Origin that carry no interior load:

- **An expedition.** Origin runs real-world and outdoor adventures all year. A whole day, outside, shoulder to shoulder, nothing to bare.
- **The Table**, a few times across the year. We eat together and the guide eats with you. Bring your own lunch, the same as everyone else does. Beyond that the ritual asks nothing of you: you do not have to eat, and nobody watches anybody's plate. *(Open: a waiting learner who cannot bring food is the same unbuilt floor as a enrolled one, and arguably sharper, since they are being invited as a guest.)*
- **The closing feast**, at the year's end.

And one that is **not the guide's to offer: the Unveiling.** Session 7 is the cohort standing up and saying "this is me" to a real audience. Whether a future cohort-mate sits in that audience is **the cohort's call, not the guide's**, made with the Cohort Call primitive. If they say no, that is a full and honored answer and the waiting learner is never told it was a no about them.

(Note the Guest Chair logic here: the proudest public act structurally includes someone from outside. This is that instinct, aimed one season forward.)

---

6. How much room, honestly

This is the captain's dial, and it changes nothing structural.

If the learner can…	Then
Not be in the room at all this year	The Ballast plus the Open Days, as above
Come some mornings	Come. Self-guided mornings are the natural fit: they are already the shape of a day a learner runs themselves. The Ballast becomes unnecessary in most of its parts
Come most of the year but not enroll	Then this is a different conversation, and it is a Family Charter and counsel question, not a packet question

In every case, the rule holds: more room is better than more paper. Paper is what we send when the room is genuinely out of reach.

---

7. The questions that are not ours to answer

- **Is a Ballast learner enrolled?** No. They are a named yes on the waitlist. That distinction is load-bearing for duty of care, consent, and insurance, and it goes to counsel with the Family Charter.
- **Does money change hands? No.** The Ballast is a gift. The moment a family pays for it, it is a product and a correspondence course, and every rule in section 4 collapses at once.
- **Who decides about the Unveiling?** The cohort, through the Cohort Call. Not the guide.

---

8. What to say, in one paragraph

> *Your learner said yes, and the room is full this year. Here is what that actually means. The Launch Pad turns like seasons, so there is no Year One to miss. They will start at The Forge next August, walk The Helm, then walk Origin, and launch having done all three. The Forge is honestly the kindest season to walk into new. They do not need to prepare, and nothing is expected of them between now and then. I am giving them a notebook that will be theirs for three years, a card about dreaming, a card about the one thing they get to love for no reason, and a weekly planner if they want one. Nobody will read any of it. If they never open it, they arrive exactly on time. And I will invite them on an expedition or two and to a few shared meals this year, because the best preparation for a room is having been in it.*

---

9. Before first use

- [ ] The joiner scaffold built (Fast-Origin seed, Log day one, peer-witness pairing, shared threshold) - owed by the Forge year plan before any joiner arrives, independent of this document
- [ ] Chekov Tier-1 read on the four printed pieces
- [ ] Accord reads the paragraph in section 8 and the “arriving empty” line for the exhale
- [ ] Comes walks it as the waiting sixteen-year-old
- [ ] The Cohort Call primitive drafted (one page) before any Unveiling invitation is considered
- [ ] Counsel: enrolled-or-not, with the Family Charter
- [ ] Naomi’s watch armed: the day The Ballast is sold, scaled, checked-in-on, or sent to someone who has not already said yes

---

Ballast is not cargo. Nothing here is homework. The room is the thing; this is just what we hand you while you wait for it.

“We evoke - we never extract.”